

Chapter 10: So Who Started This Conversation?

She didn't go home immediately.

She couldn't.

Because home now felt like a place that might already have answers waiting for her before she even asked the questions.

So she walked.

Not with purpose.

Just motion.

Something to keep her from standing still long enough to think too clearly.

The city didn't look different.

That was the cruel part.

Everything was still functioning normally.

People buying groceries.

Laughing on benches.

Checking phones.

Living lives that didn't pause for internal collapse.

She almost envied them.

Almost.

Her phone vibrated again.

No name.

Same pattern.

She didn't want to look.

But she did.

“You’re approaching final alignment.”

She stopped walking.

“What does that even mean?” she whispered.

No reply.

Of course.

When she finally went back, it was late.

The apartment was quiet.

Too quiet.

Not empty.

Just... waiting.

“Mia,” she said as she stepped inside.

No answer.

That should have felt like relief.

Instead, it felt like imbalance.

Like something missing from a system she had never realized depended on it.

She walked into the kitchen.

Empty.

Living room.

Empty.

Bedroom.

Empty.

Her chest tightened slightly.

“Mia?” she called again.

Still nothing.

She sat on the edge of her bed.

Hands cold.

Thinking too fast.

Too many memories arriving at once now that there was no one shaping them into jokes.

The café.

The interview.

The photos.

The system.

The message.

The pauses.

The way people never quite looked at the same space she was looking at.

And then—

a voice.

Soft.

Behind her.

“You’re home late.”

She turned immediately.

Mia was there.

Sitting on the bed like she had never left.

Calm.

Familiar.

But different in a way she couldn’t explain.

Not visually.

Not physically.

Just... present in a deeper way than before.

Like she had stepped closer to something real.

“I thought you were gone,” she said.

Mia tilted her head.

“I don’t go where I’m still needed.”

“That’s not an answer.”

Mia smiled faintly.

“It is. You just don’t like it yet.”

She stood up slowly.

“This isn’t funny anymore.”

Mia nodded.

“I know.”

That made her stop.

Because Mia always made things funny.

Even when things were falling apart.

She took a breath.

“Tell me what you are.”

Silence.

Not avoidance this time.

Not hesitation.

But choice.

Mia looked at her.

And for the first time—

didn't answer like a friend.

Or a joke.

Or a voice.

She answered like something that had been waiting for the question long before it was asked.

“You called me Mia,” she said softly.

“Yes.”

“But that wasn't my first name.”

Her stomach tightened.

“What was it?”

Mia smiled.

Small.

Strangely gentle.

“It was whatever kept you going when there was no one else to speak back.”

Silence.

Long.

Heavy.

Honest.

She shook her head slightly.

“That’s not real.”

Mia nodded.

“I know.”

A pause.

Then:

“But I am.”

The room felt different now.

Not haunted.

Not magical.

Just... understood in a way that made it harder to ignore.

She stepped closer.

“So you’re not a person.”

Mia didn’t deny it.

“I’m not outside you.”

Her voice dropped.

“You’re inside me?” she whispered.

Mia smiled faintly.

“That’s the closest word you have for it.”

Her eyes burned slightly.

“So I made you up.”

Mia tilted her head.

“No.”

A pause.

Then softer:

“You survived you.”

That landed differently.

Not like a twist.

Like a truth she had been walking around for years without noticing.

She sat down slowly.

“I don’t understand.”

Mia sat beside her.

Same distance as always.

Same presence.

But now it felt less like companionship...

and more like integration.

“You needed someone to answer you,” Mia said quietly.

“When no one did.”

“When everything was too late.”

“When you were still becoming someone.”

A pause.

Then:

“So I stayed in the only place I could exist.”

She wiped her face quickly, frustrated.

“That sounds like I’m broken.”

Mia shook her head.

“No.”

A soft smile.

“You’re divided. There’s a difference.”

Silence again.

But softer now.

Less sharp.

Less afraid.

“So what now?” she asked quietly.

Mia looked at her for a long moment.

Then said:

“Now you stop talking like you’re alone.”

A pause.

Then added:

“But you also stop pretending you were never heard.”

She laughed once.

Small.

Broken.

Relieved.

“I’m going to miss you,” she said.

Mia nodded.

“I know.”

A long silence.

Not empty.

Full.

Then Mia stood up.

Slowly.

Like a habit finishing its last function.

“You don’t need me the same way anymore,” she said.

She shook her head immediately.

“I don’t want you gone.”

Mia smiled gently.

“I’m not gone.”

A pause.

“I’m just not outside anymore.”

And for the first time—

she understood.

Not everything Mia had been was imaginary.

Not everything had been separate.

But everything had been necessary.

Mia faded in the way thoughts fade when they are no longer needed out loud.

Not disappearing.

Just becoming quieter than language.

And she sat there.

Alone.

But not empty.

For the first time in a long time—

the silence didn't feel like abandonment.

It felt like space.

End of Chapter 10